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ABSTRACT
This study aimed to investigate the relationship between three types of social media use and four dimensions of political participation on Facebook. Taking Vietnam as a context, we further looked into the mediating role of two related but distinct concepts of nationalism and patriotism in this process. Findings from a cross-sectional survey revealed that active nonsocial Facebook use was positively related to nationalist and patriotic attitudes. In turn, we found a negative association between nationalist attitude and counter engagement, including hacktivism and uncivil commenting. By and large, our study contributes to the growing body of research about digital nationalism in authoritarian states and the manifestation of political participation within this setting.

KEYWORDS
Digital nationalism; patriotism; social media use; political participation; authoritarian state

The contemporary digital environment decentralizes the production and circulation of national meanings. No longer confined to state institutions, elite discourse, or traditional mass media, citizens now operate as co-creators of cultural and political narratives, contributing to what scholars identify as a more participatory, affective, and performative public sphere (Papacharissi, 2015). This shift underscores the need to study everyday nationalism as something that emerges not only from government-led propaganda but also from the routine practices, interactions, and mediated engagements of ordinary users.

Vietnam offers a compelling case for examining political attitudes in such an environment. Since April 2025, the central state apparatus has been consolidated, with ministries and ministerial-level agencies reduced to 17. In June 2025, the National Assembly approved the Resolution on Provincial Administrative Reorganization, restructuring subnational governance into 34 provincial-level units (28 provinces and 6 cities), down from 63 provinces. Wards and communes were reduced by 70% (An, 2025), and the public sector workforce by 20% (Zing News, 2025). These reforms, dubbed "Doi Moi 2.0," are framed as a response to weak and incoherent institutions, which have historically been associated with corruption, rent-seeking, and occasional resistance to central directives (Ngo & Tarko, 2018; Nguyen, 2024).

Media coverage of the reforms has been celebratory, framing them as part of the Communist Party's plan to usher Vietnam through an "era of prosperity" amid global uncertainty (Cave & Ngo, 2026; Hoang & Pham, 2025). The state has concurrently intensified public displays of national pride through large-scale military parades, commemorations of the 50th anniversary of reunification, and celebrations of 80 years of independence. Patriotic imagery has proliferated across state-sponsored films, merchandise, concerts, and mass cultural events.

Since 2008, Facebook has emerged as one of the most significant arenas for public discourse in Vietnam, reshaping how information circulates and how authority is negotiated (Bui, 2017; Le et al., 2024). Vietnamese users held roughly 110 million domestic and 203 million foreign social media accounts, including 72 million on Facebook (VOH, 2025). Facebook remains the country's dominant social platform, widely used despite state attempts to promote domestic alternatives and regulate online speech. Facebook now functions as a central site for news consumption,

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political discussion, and the exchange of perspectives that fall outside the boundaries of state media (Le et al., 2024). It combines the open content sharing that Zalo lacks, the sustained discursive interaction that TikTok's entertainment orientation discourages, and the demographic breadth that X has not achieved. Its reach has compelled government ministries to engage directly with citizens online, using the platform to address rumors, respond to criticism, and promote transparency. The result is a hybrid media environment in which state narratives coexist uneasily with user-generated content and informal news networks (Le et al., 2024). This raises critical questions about how different types of Facebook use (i.e., active social, active nonsocial, and passive) relate to nationalist and patriotic attitudes, and how these attitudes might shape concrete political participation.

This paper contributes to current research in several ways. First, previous research has emphasized the need to distinguish between two related concepts of nationalism and patriotism (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989). This study centers around this distinction, separating nationalist from patriotic attitudes, in an attempt to disentangle their effects on political participation. In doing so, it adds to the body of research on digital nationalism in authoritarian states, wherein the online environment is dominated by state-led nationalist and patriotic content, in combination with grassroots participation in co-producing and spreading such content. Second, we looked into different modes of social media use, namely active social, active nonsocial, and passive Facebook use. While most studies consider social media use in general, this approach allows us to analyze how each type of Facebook use was related to nationalist and patriotic attitudes. This study focused on Facebook, the most prominent social media platform in Viet Nam, as a proxy for its online public sphere. Third, we investigated online participation in a country where most offline political movements are managed through formal structured institutionalization. In this context, the online environment gives way to alternative modes of participation and citizenship practice. Research on political participation and networks via the public sphere and media has been rooted mostly in the discourse of Western political contexts (Campbell, 2013). Fourth, using Viet Nam as a case study, we expanded academic knowledge beyond the dominant Western research. Collectively, these contributions advance theory about how digital nationalism shapes online political participation.

Theoretical framework

Defining authoritarian regime

Our theoretical discussion begins with a definition of the very context of our study – the authoritarian regime. Among multiple approaches to defining autocracies and democracies, this study adopts an institutional definition. Following established practices, we define regimes as formal and informal rules that determine which and how political leaderships are selected into key governmental offices, namely the chief executive office and legislative body (Cheibub et al., 2010; Geddes et al., 2014). In democratic regimes, these office holders are chosen through free, fair, and frequent elections – where elections is open to more than one competitive party; the outcome of each election is uncertain before it takes place and is upheld after it is done; and elections are repeated at regular and known intervals (Cheibub et al., 2010; Przeworski, 1991). In contrast, an authoritarian regime is defined as a regime where at least one of the above criteria is absent from the political leadership selection process. Vietnam has been consistently categorized as an autocratic state in various datasets about political regimes (Cheibub et al., 2010; Geddes et al., 2014; Lundquist et al., 2026).

Defining nationalist and patriotic attitude

Defining and operationalizing nationalism and its attitudinal manifestations has been a critical yet challenging task for scholars. This study adopted a widely used categorization proposed by Kosterman and Feshbach (1989): nationalism versus patriotism. In essence, nationalism is a positive attachment to one's nation due to the belief in their nation's superiority over others. Meanwhile, patriotism refers to a positive attachment to the nation without beliefs of national superiority.

Scholars have long shown that Vietnamese nationalism and patriotism are not fixed or monolithic, continually evolving under the influences of history, ideology, and globalization. Earlier forms of collective solidarity amounted to a kind of "proto-nationalism" – resistance-driven and affective, yet lacking the institutional architecture and conceptual vocabulary that would only emerge through colonial confrontation and revolutionary state-building (Le et al., 2024; Vu, 2007). More recently, the state and its elites ultimately "embraced a considerably greater range of past practices as part of Vietnamese cultural heritage and identity" (Luong, 2007, p. 445–446), indicating a shift toward a broader, more inclusive cultural nationalism (Le et al., 2024; Luong, 2007; Vu, 2007).

Facebook use and nationalist attitude

The rise social media and mass communication paved the way to a new manifestation of nationalism – digital nationalism (i.e., how algorithms, platform architectures, and user-generated content collectively mediate experiences of national belonging and reproduce symbolic boundaries within online communities; Mihelj & Jiménez-Martínez, 2021). Drawing on Gerson et al. (2017), this study distinguishes among three types of Facebook use: active social, active nonsocial, and passive. Active social involves direct, written interpersonal communication among users, such as writing posts, commenting on friends' wall, and exchanging messages. Active nonsocial use involves behaviors that do not require interpersonal exchange, such as liking and reacting to posts, and responding to event invitations. Passive Facebook use refers to consumption of content without any forms of interaction, including scrolling through newsfeeds, viewing photos, and monitoring what others are doing. The distinction among these constructs are important as it reflects the variance in personalities and well-being of Facebook users (Gerson et al., 2017).

These three types are associated with nationalist and patriotic attitudes through different mechanisms. Active social use immerses users in a highly interactive environment where emotional and ideological cues are continually exchanged. The digital environment in authoritarian states is saturated with both user-generated nationalistic content and government-led nationalist agendas (Hyun & Kim, 2015), amplifying emotional intensity and in-group/out-group boundaries. Research on group polarization suggests that discussion among like-minded individuals tends to shift attitudes toward more extreme positions (Isenberg, 1986; Sunstein, 2002), with such dynamics especially computer-mediated settings (Sia et al., 2002). The emotionally charged nature of these exchanges makes active social use particularly conducive to nationalist attitudes, characterized by hostility and out-group segregation, while also strengthening patriotic attitudes through affirmation of shared values. Nationalist attitudes are therefore expected to be more strongly associated with active social use than patriotic attitudes.

Active nonsocial Facebook use, despite limited deliberate engagement, can still strengthen political attitudes through processes such as cognitive consistency (Abelson et al., 1968). The online environment in authoritarian regimes strongly reflects the nationalistic sentiment preferred by the authority, with limited alternative discourses (see He, 2018; Huang & Lee, 2003; Hyun et al., 2014). In such a homogenous environment, habitual liking and sharing nationalist content may facilitate the development and reinforcement of political values, beliefs, and ideology (Gainous & Wagner, 2023; Seliktar, 1980). However, given the lack of emotional escalation inherent to interpersonal exchange, the link to nationalist attitude is expected to be lower compared to active social Facebook use.

Passive Facebook use reflects the ambient consumption of content without active engagement. Previous studies showed that mere exposure to media content, specifically nationalistic cues, can increase nationalism across political contexts (Kemmelmeier & Winter, 2008; Li & Guo, 2018). In other words, while seeing the homogeneous discussion online, passive users are likely to interpret the public discourse as unanimous and nationalistic. This might lead to internalization of nationalist and patriotic attitudes through mechanisms of norm perception and heuristic processing. While these mechanisms can produce gradual internalization of prevailing attitudes, they are less

likely to evoke affective arousal and out-group antagonism characterizing nationalist attitudes. Therefore, we expected the association between passive Facebook use and nationalist attitude to be the weakest.

Based on these theoretical considerations, we formulated the following hypothesis:

H1. There is a positive relationship between Facebook use and nationalist attitude, such that active social Facebook use has the strongest association, followed by active nonsocial, and passive Facebook use.

While all three forms of Facebook use are expected to positively relate to patriotic attitudes, the theoretical basis for predicting differential effects across use types is less clear. Patriotic sentiment, rooted in positive in-group attachment (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989), may be reinforced equally through deliberative interaction and ambient symbolic exposure (Billig, 1995). Therefore, we posed the following research question:

RQ1. Is there a difference among the association of active social, active nonsocial, and passive social Facebook use and patriotic attitude?

Online political participation and nationalist attitude

The spread of digital media has changed what it means for citizens to take part in politics (Cammaerts et al., 2013; Pickard, 2019). Many online political acts, such as following a political page, reacting to a news post, or quietly reading a heated comment thread, have little offline equivalent that fits the conventional definition of political participation. They are therefore better understood as a separate mode of participation (Theocharis et al., 2022). Because these acts depend on the features of the platform where they happen (Theocharis et al., 2022; Velasco et al., 2024), participation on one platform cannot be assumed to look like participation on another. Moreover, much politically relevant activity consists of attention to and interest in politics that precedes, and may never become, manifest action (Ekman & Amnå, 2012). This is particularly true among young users, who mainly use social media for social interaction (Ekström & Shehata, 2016). This study therefore examines Facebook, the dominant platform for social interaction in Vietnam, and asks how political activity appears within a space mostly used for other purposes.

To capture this range of activity, we draw on Waeterloos et al. (2021) typology of social media political participation, which distinguishes four forms of engagement. Latent engagement refers to attentiveness-oriented behaviors, such as following political news and discussions. Expressive engagement comprises publicly visible acts, such as posting opinions or sharing political content. Follower engagement involves participatory acts within closed groups of like-minded users (Vraga et al., 2015). Counter engagement refers to acts that challenge or push back against political content one disagrees with.

Although less widely used than active/passive distinctions, the typology separates these activities along two dimensions central to this study. The first is scope, meaning how visible an activity is to others. The second is valence, meaning whether an activity affirms, defends, or leaves open a political position. Its inclusion of private forms matters empirically. Among Filipino youth, latent and follower engagement were moderate while expressive engagement was low (Velasco et al., 2024). In Vietnam's regulated online environment, a focus on expressive acts alone would likely underestimate political engagement.

The four forms also plausibly differ in how they relate to ideological commitment. Latent engagement is private and directionally open, since what is read may be processed in any direction. Expressive engagement is public but not tied to a particular direction. It is more likely among those who perceive their views as widely shared (Noelle-Neumann, 1974) and those with more extreme orientations (Baldassare & Katz, 1996; Shamir, 1997). Stating a position before others can also strengthen it, as public commitment creates pressure for consistency (Deutsch & Gerard, 1955; Festinger, 1957). Follower engagement is semi-private and affirmative, and such value-congruent spaces allow group polarization to amplify shared views (Isenberg, 1986; Sunstein, 2002). Counter engagement is public and defensive. It is mobilized when a valued position or identity is felt to be under challenge.

Read against the distinction between nationalism and patriotism (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989), these dimensions suggest that the two attitudes need not relate to online participation similarly. Given its belief in national superiority and desire for dominance over other nations, nationalism should matter most where engagement is visible, allowing the in-group to be asserted before others. It should also matter most where engagement is defensive, responding to perceived challenges to the in-group's standing. Its association should thus be strongest for counter engagement and weaken as engagement becomes less public and less oppositional:

H2. There is a positive relationship between nationalist attitude and political engagement, such that counter engagement has the strongest association, followed by expressive engagement, follower engagement, and latent engagement.

Patriotism, by contrast, rests on positive attachment to the nation without necessary out-group hostility. Lacking a defensive component, it offers no clear basis for ranking associations across the four forms. Affirmative attachment may relate to latent and expressive engagement, whereas its link to counter engagement is uncertain. We therefore ask:

RQ2. Is there a difference among the relationships between patriotic attitude and different types of online political engagement (i.e., latent political engagement, counter political engagement, expressive political engagement, and follower political engagement)?

Moderating effects of network heterogeneity

Network heterogeneity is defined as the extent to which an individual's conversation partners consist of people with different demographic characteristics and socio-political background (Eveland & Hively, 2009; Scheufele et al., 2006). Within a heterogeneous network, social media users are more likely to come across information that they disagree with or those about political issues that they might otherwise overlook (Brundidge, 2010; Scheufele et al., 2006). This interaction facilitates discussion via commenting and attitude negotiation. One strand of research argues that network heterogeneity encourages political discussion and tolerance (see J. Lee & Choi, 2019; Parsons, 2010). Deliberative researchers believe that the ambivalence and confusion stemmed from opposing discussions and challenging opinions, which encouraged people to adjust their worldviews in a balanced way (Lowell, 1913). Other scholars claimed that network heterogeneity does not necessarily lead to a change in attitude (see Chen et al., 2022; J. K. Lee et al., 2014). Through processes like motivated reasoning (Taber & Lodge, 2006) that can be provoked by engaging in heterogeneous networks, individuals might be more likely to defend their current position, thereby reinforcing preexisting beliefs. Following previous research, we expect network heterogeneity to moderate the relationship between social media use and political attitudes.

Nationalist discourse consistently frames the "self" against an "other," reinforcing exclusion and negative representations of adversarial groups (Ali et al., 2022). This kind of communication effectively fosters exclusionary nationalism (Saresma & Tulonen, 2020). In contrast, patriotism reflects a positive attachment to the nation that does not require hostility toward the "other" reinforced through "banal digital nationalism," where digital infrastructures continually reproduce national categories (Mihelj & Jiménez-Martínez, 2021), and supported by the endurance of national identity even in deterritorialized and transnational contexts (Eriksen, 2007). Because patriotism centers on symbolic belonging rather than antagonism toward an out-group, patriotic attitudes may remain consistent or even become more pronounced across different degrees of network heterogeneity. In this line, research shows that homogeneous online communities intensify radicalization and extremism, while heterogeneous networks expose individuals to politically dissimilar viewpoints that can temper or moderate extremist tendencies (Wojcieszak, 2010).

Building on this line of reasoning, we expected separate mechanisms for the effect on nationalist and patriotic attitudes: nationalist attitudes are

expected to be more sensitive to the structure of users' networks and therefore exhibit stronger moderation effects, while patriotic attitudes, anchored in symbolic belonging rather than antagonism, should display minimal moderation. We formulated a research question as follows:

RQ3. How does network heterogeneity moderate the relationship between Facebook use and (a) nationalist attitude and (b) patriotic attitude?

The theoretical model is presented in Figure 1:

Methodology

Sample

The survey was originally developed in English and then translated into Vietnamese, with minor linguistic adaptations to ensure clarity and contextual relevance. Participants were recruited using a convenience sampling strategy through the researchers' personal networks and social media. To be eligible, respondents had to (1) be at least 18 years old, (2) currently reside in Vietnam, and (3) provide informed consent. After excluding incomplete responses and respondents completing the survey below one-third of the sample's median duration, the final samples consisted of $N = 536$ participants, including 64.6% ($N = 356$) women and 31.5% ($N = 169$) men.

The sample was predominantly young: 77.1% ($N = 413$) were between 18 and 24 years old, and 20% ($N = 107$) were between 25 and 34 years old. Regarding education, 65.3% ($N = 350$) had a high education level (i.e., obtained at least a bachelor's degree), whereas 34.7% ($N = 186$) had low-level education (i.e., completed high school education or lower). The skew toward younger respondents in this sample reflects broader demographic and political realities relevant to the study of online engagement in Vietnam. According to Chi (2026), the working-age population (15–59) accounted for approximately 62.7% of the country's 102.3 million people. Moreover, youth have been identified as central to contemporary forms of political engagement, particularly within digital environments (e.g., Bennett et al., 2009; Fieldhouse et al., 2007; Loader et al., 2012). The final sample was unevenly distributed across the three main regions in Vietnam regarding origin and upbringing background, with more than half of respondents from Northern Vietnam ($N = 302$), 23.7% from the Central region ($N = 127$), and 19.8% from the South ($N = 106$) (see Table 1).

Procedure

Data was collected from November 17 to 30, 2025. Participants were first given general information about the survey together with information on recontact procedures and their participant rights. Upon providing consent, participants were then asked about their sociodemographics, including age, gender, education, and location. After this, we presented them with four blocks in a fixed order: (a) social media use, (b) network heterogeneity, (c) nationalistic and patriotic attitude, and (d) online political participation. At the end, participants were debriefed and given room for feedback. The data is collected as a case study of a historically significant event in response to Vietnamese government reforms officially implemented on 1 July 2025.

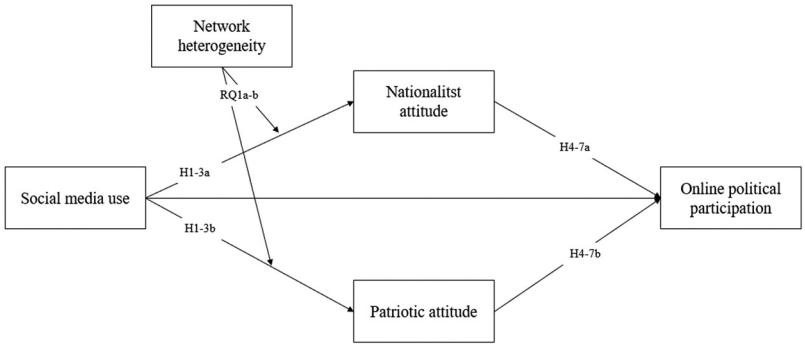


Figure 1. Theoretical model.

Table 1. Characteristics of the study sample (N = 536).

	n	% of sample
Age		
18–24 years old	413	77.2%
25–34 years old	107	20%
35–44 years old	8	1.5%
45 years old and above	7	1.3%
Gender		
Men	169	31.5%
Women	346	64.6%
Other	21	3.9%
Highest educational degree obtained		
Elementary education	0	0%
Secondary education	2	0.4%
High school	184	34.3%
Vocational training/ College	8	1.5%
Bachelor's degree	276	51.5%
Master's degree	59	11%
Doctoral degree	7	1.3%
Origin & upbringing background		
Northern region	302	56.3%
Central region	127	23.7%
Southern region	106	20%

Measures

Facebook use

To measure respondents' Facebook use, we adapted the three-item Passive Active User Measure from Gerson et al. (2017). On 5-point Likert scales (1 = never, 5 = very frequently), participants were asked how frequently they perform 13 activities on Facebook. For active social use ($M = 2.8$, $SD = 0.75$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .70$, 95% CI [.65, .73]), the items were: (1) posting status updates, (2) commenting, (3) chatting on Messenger, (4) posting photos, and (5) browsing the newsfeed actively (liking and commenting). For active non-social use ($M = 1.6$, $SD = 0.70$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .74$, 95% CI [.70, .77]), the items were: (1) creating or RSVPing to events, (2) tagging photos, (3) posting videos, and (4) tagging videos. For passive use ($M = 3.4$, $SD = 0.83$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .59$, 95% CI [.53, .65]), the items were: (1) checking to see what someone is up to, (2) viewing photos, (3) browsing the newsfeed passively (without liking or commenting) and (4) looking through friends' profiles. For all three latent variables, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) shows a good model fit: $\chi2(62) = 314.55$, $p < .001$, CFI = .865, RMSEA = .087 (90%-CI[.08; .10]), SRMR = .07.

Network heterogeneity

Network heterogeneity was assessed by eight items on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = never, 5 = very frequently). Participants were asked to indicate how frequently they discuss socio-political matters with people from different (1) ethnicity, (2) language, (3) social status, (4) education, (5) religion, (6) gender, (7) age, and (8) region. CFA shows a good model fit: $\chi2(20) = 130.26$, $p < .001$, CFI = .921, RMSEA = .101 (90%-CI[.09; .12]), SRMR = .050. These five items also showed good internal consistency ($M = 2.6$, $SD = 0.86$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .85$, 95% CI [.83, .87].

Nationalist attitude

We adapted two items from Dekker et al. (2003). On 5-point Likert scales (1 = totally disagree, 5 = totally agree), participants were asked to what extent they agree with the presented statements. The two-factor model showed acceptable model fit: $\chi2(188) = 854.97$, $p < .001$, CFI = .900, RMSEA = .081 (90%-CI[.08, .09]), SRMR = .05. The two latent variables, nationalism ($M = 4.1$, $SD = 0.60$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .82$, 95% CI [.80, .85] and patriotism ($M = 3.7$, $SD = 0.87$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .89$, 95% CI [.87, .90], were highly correlated ($r = .86$, $p < .001$).

Online political participation

We measure online political participation with four dimensions: latent, counter, expressive and follower engagement on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = never, 5 = very frequently), adapted from Waeterloos et al. (2021). For the four-factors model, CFA shows acceptable fit: $\chi2(113) = 589.53$, $p < .001$, CFI = .871, RMSEA = .089 (90%-CI[.08; .10]), SRMR = .07. These dimensions showed acceptable internal consistency: latent engagement ($M = 3.1$, $SD = 0.94$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .80$, 95% CI [.77, .82]); expressive engagement ($M = 2.5$, $SD = 1.10$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .69$, 95% CI [.64, .73]); follower engagement ($M = 2.0$, $SD = 0.91$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .80$, 95% CI [.77, .83]) while counter engagement ($M = 2.2$, $SD = 0.85$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .60$, 95% CI [.54, .65]) was lower.

Statistical analysis

We test the proposed hypotheses through two sets of analyses. First, zero-order and partial-order Pearson's correlations are computed to allow the examination of correlational associations between

variables. Second, we conduct path analysis, which enables the testing of a priori theoretical causal models. Specifically, path analysis allows for the simultaneous estimation of multiple direct and indirect relationships among observed variables, making it well-suited for testing a theoretical model that specifies direct and indirect associations between several predictors, mediators, and outcomes within a single framework (Kim et al., 2020; Streiner, 2005). However, the results of path analysis should be interpreted as suggesting potential pathways among the variables rather than causal confirmation.

In our study, path analysis was done using a maximum-likelihood estimator, full information maximum-likelihood procedure, and bootstrapped standard error to 1000. We entered active social, active nonsocial, and passive Facebook use as independent variables, network heterogeneity as the moderator, nationalist and patriotic attitude as mediators, and four types of online political participation as dependent variables. We further control for a set of demographic covariates.

Results

Zero-order Pearson's correlation analysis showed small to moderate associations among active social, active nonsocial, and passive Facebook use (rs = .27 - .58). Active social Facebook use was weakly related to nationalist and patriotist attitudes (rs = .13 - .17). Likewise, active nonsocial Facebook use was weakly associated with the mediators (rs = .22 - .23). Passive Facebook use was only significantly related to nationalist attitudes ($r = .12$). Network heterogeneity has a statistically significant association with Facebook use (rs = .23 - .26), but not with nationalist and patriotic attitudes. Meanwhile, nationalist and patriotic attitudes were strongly related to each other ($r = .86$). (see Table 2)

Model testing

Inspection of direct associations along each path of the model showed a positive relationship between active nonsocial Facebook use and nationalist attitudes, $b = .31$, $SE = .15$, $p = .032$. We found no correlation between active social Facebook use, $b = -.04$, $SE = .16$, $p = .803$, or passive Facebook use, $b = -.14$, $SE = .11$, $p = .218$, and nationalist attitudes. Active nonsocial Facebook use is also positively associated with patriotic attitudes, $b = .48$, $SE = .17$, $p = .006$. Meanwhile, no association was found between patriotic attitudes and active social Facebook use, $b = -.16$, $SE = .19$, $p = .424$, or passive Facebook use, $b = -.20$, $SE = .13$, $p = .134$.

There was a negative relationship between network heterogeneity and nationalist attitude, $b = -.36$, $SE = .13$, $p = .007$. However, the relationship between Facebook use and nationalist attitudes does not appear to be moderated by network heterogeneity. Likewise, we found a mild and statistically significant association of network heterogeneity on patriotic attitudes, $b = -.52$, $SE = .18$, $p = .004$, but no moderating effects were detected (see Table 3)

The four types of online political participation were moderately related to one another (see Table 2). There was no statistical relationship between nationalist attitude, $b = -.05$, $SE = .12$, $p = 679$, or patriotic attitude, $b = -.09$, $SE = .10$, $p = .342$, and latent engagement. Nationalist attitudes were weakly associated to counter engagement, $b = -.28$, $SE = .11$, $p = .009$. However, no such relationship was found for patriotic attitudes, $b = -.02$, $SE = .09$, $p = .792$. Regarding expressive engagement, we found no association between this kind

Table 2. Zero-order correlations.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Active social SMU									
2. Active nonsocial SMU	0.58***								
3. Passive SMU	0.45***	0.27***							
4. Nationalist attitude	0.17***	0.22***	0.12**						
5. Patriotic attitude	0.13**	0.23***	0.07	0.86***					
6. Network heterogeneity	0.26***	0.25***	0.23***	−0.04	−0.07				
7. Latent engagement	0.14**	0.04	0.17***	−0.07	−0.08	0.39***			
8. Counter engagement	0.15***	0.14**	0.13**	−0.18***	−0.15***	0.31***	0.49***		
9. Expressive engagement	0.18***	0.12**	0.12**	−0.09*	−0.11*	0.31***	0.59***	0.57***	
10. Follower engagement	0.19***	0.12**	0.12**	−0.22***	−0.23***	0.37***	0.49***	0.65***	0.60***

Table 3. Effects of social media use and network heterogeneity on nationalist attitude and patriotic attitude.

	Nationalist Attitude *B (SE), .*	Patriotic Attitude *B (SE), .*
Active social Facebook use (ASFU)	−.04 (.16), −.05	−.16 (.19), −.14
Active nonsocial Facebook use (ANFU)	.31 (.16), .33*	.48 (.17), .39**
Passive Facebook use (PFU)	−.14 (.11), .18	−.20 (.13), −.19
Network heterogeneity (NH)	−.36 (.13), −.47**	−.52 (.18), −.51**
ASFU x NH	.04 (.05), .19	.07 (.07), .30
ANFU x NH	−.05 (.05), −.23	−.07 (.06), −.24
PFU x NH	.07 (.04), .46	.08 (.05), .38
Age (25–34)	−.29 (.08), −.18***	−.37 (.10), −.17***
Age (35–44)	−.24 (.19), −.04	−.52 (.31), −.07
Age (45 and above)	.05 (.15), .01	−.41 (.29), −.05
Gender (Female)	.05 (.06), .04	.09 (.08), .05
Gender (Others)	−.53 (.15), −.16***	−.58 (.21), −.13**
Education	.001 (.06), .001*	.02 (.08), .01

Table 4. Effects of nationalist attitude and patriotic attitude on online political participation.

	Latent Engagement *B (SE), .*	Counter Engagement *B (SE), .*	Expressive Engagement *B (SE), .*	Follower Engagement *B (SE), .*
Nationalist attitude	−.05 (.12), −.03	−.28 (.11), −.21**	.01 (.14) .01	−.19 (.12), −.14
Patriotic attitude	−.09 (.10), −.09	−.02 (.09), −.02	−.21 (.11), −.17	−.17 (.10), −.17
Age (25–34)	−.15 (.11), −.06	−.20 (.10), −.10*	−.24 (.13), −.09	−.09 (.11), −.04
Age (35–44)	−.40 (.17), −.05*	−.00 (.37), −.00	.14 (.33), .02	−.05 (.40), −.06
Age (45 and above)	−.91 (.48), −.11	−.62 (.25), −.08*	−1.28 (.22), −.14***	−.73 (.18), −.09***
Gender (Female)	.004 (.09), .002	−.05 (.08), −.03	.14 (.10), .06	−.11 (.08), −.06
Gender (Others)	−.23 (.24), −.05	−.03 (.16), −.01	.14 (.26), .03	−.13 (.21) −.03
Education	−.17 (.09), .09	−.03 (.08), −.01	−.004 (.10), −.002	−.12 (.08), −.06

of OPP and nationalist attitude, $b = .01$, $SE = .14$, $p = .947$, and patriotic attitude, $b = -.21$, $SE = .11$, $p = .058$. Nationalist and patriotic attitudes were also not related to follower engagement (see Table 4).

In terms of direct paths between variables, results suggested a positive relationship between active social Facebook use and latent engagement, $b = .15$, $SE = .07$, $p = .042$, as well as expressive engagement, $b = .23$, $SE = .09$, $p = .009$, and follower engagement, $b = .22$, $SE = .07$, $p = .003$. Besides, passive Facebook use was found to positively correlate with latent engagement, $b = .14$, $SE = .06$, $p = .015$.

Discussion

The present study examined the role of social media use in facilitating and inhibiting online political participation among Vietnamese youth. Specifically, we looked into the relationship between three types of Facebook use, namely active social, active nonsocial, and passive, and four dimensions of online political participation, namely latent engagement, counter engagement, expressive engagement, and follower engagement. Further, we investigated the mediating role of nationalist and patriotic attitudes in this process. We focused on Facebook because it is the dominant social media site in Vietnam. With the internet penetration rate of 79% in 2024 (Kemp, 2024), Facebook has become the main space for information sharing and public discussion. In this sense, it provides a compelling platform to study public opinion in the country.

Central to our study is the distinction between nationalist and patriotic attitudes. Previous research differentiates nationalism from patriotism by attributing a sense of national superiority to the former (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989). Despite this conceptual distinction, our data showed that nationalist and patriotic attitudes were empirically highly correlated. This is a substantive political-cultural finding that distinctly reflects Vietnamese digital space. Through decades of state-sponsored media, education and public commemoration, emotional attachment to the nation with pride in the superiority of its developmental model have been systematically presented as a unified civic identity in official discourse (Le et al., 2024;

Luong, 2007; Vu, 2007). This fusion has deep historical roots in Vietnam's experience of colonization, resistance, and state-building, through which sovereignty, sacrifice, and national pride were co-constructed into a single affective formation (Luong, 2007; Vu, 2007), making the Western theoretical separation between patriotism and nationalism difficult to sustain empirically (Mihelj & Jiménez-Martínez, 2021). This dynamic was further intensified by two nationwide celebrations in 2025 (Le et al., 2024). Our study took place after the height of these events, yet people were still immersed in the nationalistic atmosphere that mixed nationalist and patriotic discussions. Vietnamese youth in this study do not differentiate between nationalist and patriotic attitudes. This marks a gap between Western theoretical distinctions and non-Western political practice that warrants further investigation in the future.

Facebook use and nationalist and patriotic attitudes

Our main finding indicates a positive relationship between active nonsocial Facebook use and both nationalist and patriotic attitudes, with no significant difference between the two paths. This result aligns with prior research showing that information consumption on social media reinforces nationalist attitudes in authoritarian settings (Guo et al., 2007; Shen & Guo, 2013), and that social media use is associated with attitude extremity across topics (Gainous & Wagner, 2023). Vietnam's digital information environment is characterized by a high prevalence of state-aligned and citizen-generated nationalist content, with limited circulation of alternative discourses. Within this environment, users are frequently exposed to pro-attitudinal messages from both official and peer sources, producing a reinforcing dynamic in which information consumption and existing attitudes mutually strengthen one another, consolidating nationalist and patriotic orientations.

We found no moderating effect of network heterogeneity on the relationship between Facebook use and nationalist attitude or patriotic attitude. Nevertheless, there was a direct effect of network heterogeneity such that nationalist and patriotic attitudes increased with the decrease in heterogeneous networks. It should be noted that the degree of heterogeneity in our sample is relatively low. Participants generally do not often interact with people from different socioeconomic backgrounds, suggesting a certain level of network homophily on Vietnamese Facebook. This is primarily due to the nature of Facebook connections, which are rooted in real-life social contacts (Miller et al., 2015). In addition, Facebook algorithms curate content based on past behavior, narrowing the novelty and diversity of what people encounter. Because people from homophilous networks less often diverge in opinions to gain social approval and a positive sense of self (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004), those who already hold nationalist and patriotic attitudes fall into an echo chamber that reinforces their existing attitudes. This highlights the fact that social networking sites like Facebook might reinforce nationalism and patriotism instead of promoting a deliberative citizenry (Chan, 2017).

Political attitudes and online political participation

In recent years, scholars have paid significant attention to the manifestation of online political participation. While some forms of online political participation are extensions of offline activities (e.g., signing a petition), other argues that they constitute a separate mode of participation (Gibson & Cantijoch, 2013; Theocharis & Van Deth, 2018; Theocharis et al., 2019), contributing to the complexity of the current political landscape. This study focused on online-only activities, more specifically, Facebook activities, by using the typology proposed by Waeterloos et al. (2021).

Data showed a negative relationship between nationalist attitude and counter engagement. As nationalist attitudes increase, Vietnamese respondents are less likely to engage in the misuse of information or uncivil political commentary. This finding stands in tension with previous Western literature, which has consistently linked nationalist sentiment to hostile, aggressive, and confrontational online behavior (Hyun et al., 2014; Wojcieszak, 2010). Drawing on social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986), we suggest that those with high national identification tend to evaluate

the in-group and the nation in strongly positive terms (Conover, 1988) and may regard behaviors that could publicly tarnish the nation's image – spreading misinformation, engaging in uncivil discourse, or participating in hacktivism – as inappropriate or harmful. High national identifiers may therefore self-regulate to preserve the dignity and cohesion of the in-group. This mechanism is reinforced by the broader architecture of digital nationalism in authoritarian states, where civic conduct is intertwined with rationality, discipline, and national respectability (Jiang & Esarey, 2018). Individuals endorsing nationalist values may internalize these norms and avoid counter-engagement behaviors that contradict the socially prescribed image of a "good" national citizen. In Vietnam's 2025 context, this dynamic was likely intensified by the normative saturation of the digital environment surrounding two major state anniversaries, where state-led narratives equating appropriate civic behavior with unity, loyalty, and moral righteousness narrowed the perceived legitimacy of oppositional or uncivil expression.

In terms of direct effect, we found positive relationships between active social Facebook use and latent engagement, expressive engagement, and follower engagement. These findings were supported by previous research, saying that active Internet use encourages people to participate in politics, through both online and offline means (S. Lee, 2018; Wang & Meng, 2022). Active engagement places individuals within dense networks of political conversation, enabling them to exchange views, encounter persuasive cues, and receive social reinforcement for political expression. These mechanisms help explain why active social media users are more likely to transition from political awareness to concrete participation.

Likewise, we observed a small but significant association between passive Facebook use and two types of participation: latent engagement and counter engagement. This supports the argument that political participation does not always require intentional or interactive forms of engagement; rather, mere exposure to political cues can influence political attitudes and behaviors (Beam, 2014; Valeriani & Vaccari, 2016). Passive consumption of news, posts, and commentary can increase political awareness, heighten perceived relevance of political issues, and normalize certain participatory behaviors in users' feeds (Shahin et al., 2020). Such dynamics reflect theories of incidental exposure, which suggest that individuals can become politically activated even when not explicitly seeking political content (Tewksbury et al., 2001). Further, in the context of Vietnam's heavily nationalistic digital environment, national identity becomes highly salient in political discussions. This might lead to uncivil behavior among high identifiers when coming across counter-attitudinal information.

Lastly, this study shed light on the online political participation in Viet Nam, an important but often overlooked context. Political engagement in Asia often takes subtle or indirect forms that differ from those in Western democracies (Chan, 2016; Willnat et al., 2013). The state actively promotes nationalist and patriotic narratives and uses digital platforms to steer public discourse, making Vietnam ideal for examining how identity-based attitudes shape online participation. At the same time, rising digital literacy and generational change create new opportunities for civic expression despite political constraints. Studying Vietnam, therefore, broadens comparative research on digital politics and helps illuminate how citizens participate under authoritarian conditions.

Limitations and future research

Despite these contributions, this study has several limitations. As with any cross-sectional survey, the data preclude causal inference between key variables, and a single-wave design offers only a snapshot of Vietnamese youth sentiment rather than capturing how it evolves in response to changing conditions. Future research should extend this design into a cross-sectional time-series or panel study to examine the magnitude and stability of these pathways over time.

Another limitation concerns platform generalizability. This study focuses on Facebook, which we argue is the most consequential platform for political discourse in Vietnam. However, Zalo and TikTok play distinct and increasingly important roles in the Vietnamese digital ecosystem – Zalo as a channel for state–citizen

communication, and TikTok as a site for visual and performative expression among young people. Their affordances differ substantively from Facebook's, and the dynamics observed here may not extend to them. Comparative cross-platform research is a priority in the future direction.

Because the sample is generationally bounded, the findings also cannot speak to how attitudes evolve across the life course or differ among cohorts shaped by distinct historical experiences. Future research incorporating older cohorts – including those who lived through the embargo era or the early years of Doi Moi – would enable intergenerational comparison and a richer assessment of how perspectives on reform shift over time.

The scale employed (Waeterloos et al., 2021) further captures uncivil and hacktivist behaviors broadly, without distinguishing their targets. The relationship between national attitudes and online incivility may differ depending on whether the perceived target is a fellow group member, an outgroup, or a political opponent – a question future research could address by examining the interaction between nationalism, patriotism, and other dimensions of political attitude.

Beyond methodological constraints, a theoretical extension involves moving beyond intranational dynamics to incorporate interactions between Vietnamese citizens and external actors. Because nationalism and patriotism are grounded in in-group awareness and out-group comparisons, examining how Vietnamese users engage with content and news from specific foreign countries could yield a more nuanced understanding of these attitudes – a direction particularly compelling given Vietnam's position at the crossroads of the Sinosphere and Southeast Asian cultural spheres. The sense of superiority over other nations that defines nationalism may emerge more clearly when respondents are asked about countries perceived as Vietnam's friends or foes.

Conclusion

Taking Vietnam as a case study, this paper advances current research on digital nationalism in authoritarian states. We first drew on the conceptual distinction between nationalism and patriotism, in an attempt to empirically test this theory. Data showed a positive relationship between active nonsocial Facebook use and both nationalist and patriotic attitudes. We found no moderating effect of network heterogeneity on attitude formation, though direct effects were detected. Regarding OPP, increases in nationalist attitudes were associated with decreases in hacktivism and uncivil commenting, hinting toward the in-group favoritism effect of nationalism. Overall, this study explains the mechanisms underlying Facebook use and political participation by integrating insights from the digital nationalism perspective. By and large, this research goes beyond the Western domination in political research to provide evidence for citizen-led political activities in a South East Asian country.

Author contributions

CRediT: **Giao Nguyen:** Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Uyen-Nhi Tran Le:** Data curation, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **My Nguyen:** Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Duc Anh Tu Ngo:** Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Thai Nguyen:** Methodology, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Data availability statement

The data generated and analyzed are available under OSFhttps://osf.io/w3cbg/overview?view_only=2163ab8f77054463ab7ed2e1df2f9f39

Ethical approval and informed consent statements

This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board of the Faculty of Social Sciences (IRB) at the University of Vienna (ID 20251020_076) on November 12, 2025. Informed consent was obtained from all participants involved in the study.

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